

Organizational Design for Product Teams · Session Reading List

MBA / EMBA: 1–3 readings per session, practitioner-focused, case-grounded · Graduate / Research: 6–8 readings, full organizational theory and empirical apparatus

WK	TOPIC & SESSION FOCUS	MBA / EMBA (1–3 readings) <i>Case-method and practitioner focus</i>	GRADUATE / RESEARCH (6–8 readings) <i>Full organizational theory apparatus</i>
1	Organizations as Products <i>Reframing org design as a product problem: orgs can be well or poorly designed, and that design determines what can be shipped.</i>	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2020) — SVPG — the course's primary product-management anchor - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era, Introduction (2026) — @arcktip — the course's primary practitioner framework - Conway, Melvin, How Do Committees Invent? (1968) — Datamation — Conway's Law, the foundational insight: systems mirror org structure	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Introduction & Ch. 1–5 (2020) — SVPG - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era, Introduction (2026) — @arcktip - Conway, Melvin, How Do Committees Invent? (1968) — Datamation - Galbraith, Jay, Designing Organizations, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2014) — Jossey-Bass — the Star Model of org design - Lawrence, Paul & Lorsch, Jay, Organization and Environment, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1967) — HBS Press — differentiation and integration as org design levers - Chandler, Alfred, Strategy and Structure, Introduction (1962) — MIT Press — structure follows strategy: the historical argument - Mintzberg, Henry, The Structuring of Organizations, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1979) — Prentice-Hall — five organizational configurations
2	The Rule of Seven <i>Span of control, cognitive load, and the mathematics of team size. Why seven is the constraint that shapes everything else.</i>	- Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Part I: The Framework) (2026) — @arcktip — the central analytical tool of the course - Dunbar, Robin, Neocortex Size as a Constraint on Group Size in Primates (1992) — Journal of Human Evolution — the evolutionary basis of span of control - Hackman, J. Richard, Why Teams Don't Work (HBR Interview) (2009) — HBR — the six conditions for team effectiveness	- Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Part I) (2026) — @arcktip - Dunbar, Robin, Neocortex Size as a Constraint on Group Size in Primates (1992) — Journal of Human Evolution - Hackman, J. Richard, Why Teams Don't Work (HBR Interview) (2009) — HBR - Hackman, J. Richard, Leading Teams, Introduction & Ch. 1–2 (2002) — HBS Press — the definitive academic work on team conditions - Miller, George A., The Magical Number Seven, Plus or Minus Two (1956) — Psychological Review — the cognitive science behind Dunbar and Hoffman - Ancona, Deborah & Caldwell, David, Bridging the Boundary: External Activity and Performance in Organizational Teams (1992) — Administrative Science Quarterly — team boundary management - Belbin, R. Meredith, Management Teams: Why They Succeed or Fail, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1981) — Butterworth-Heinemann — team role composition

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3	Mission-Driven Teams <i>How to write a team mission that creates alignment without mandating methods. The autonomy-coordination tension and how top product orgs resolve it.</i>	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 6–9 (Mission & Objectives) (2020) — SVPG — product team missions in practice - Doerr, John, Measure What Matters, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2018) — Portfolio — OKRs as the operating system of mission-driven teams - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Mission-Driven Teams section) (2026) — @arcktip — the five-sentence mission test	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 6–10 (2020) - Doerr, John, Measure What Matters, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2018) — Portfolio - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Mission-Driven Teams) (2026) — @arcktip - Collins, Jim & Porras, Jerry, Built to Last, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1994) — HarperBusiness — mission and BHAG at company level - Simons, Robert, Levers of Control, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1995) — HBS Press — belief, boundary, diagnostic, and interactive control systems - Edmondson, Amy, Teaming, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2012) — Jossey-Bass — dynamic teaming without fixed team membership - Grant, Adam, Originals, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2016) — Viking — how mission framing affects creative risk-taking
4	Startup Org Design <i>The 0-to-10 PM arc: when to hire generalists, when to specialize, and how to avoid premature structure that kills velocity.</i>	- Horowitz, Ben, The Hard Thing About Hard Things, Introduction & Ch. 5–6 (2014) — HarperBusiness — the CEO's guide to org design under pressure - Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 19–21 (Staffing Product Teams) (2020) — the PM hiring and team-building arc - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Startup Org Design section) (2026) — @arcktip — the practitioner's guide to startup org design	- Horowitz, Ben, The Hard Thing About Hard Things, Introduction & Ch. 5–7 (2014) — HarperBusiness - Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 19–23 (2020) - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Startup Org Design) (2026) — @arcktip - Blank, Steve, The Four Steps to the Epiphany, Ch. 3–4 (2005) — the customer discovery arc and org implications - Eisenmann, Thomas, Why Startups Fail, Introduction & Ch. 1–2 (2021) — Currency — org design failures in early-stage companies - Feld, Brad & Mendelson, Jason, Venture Deals, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2019) — Wiley — how funding rounds shape org design constraints - Catmull, Ed, Creativity, Inc., Introduction & Ch. 1–2 (2014) — Random House — org design for creative product teams at scale
5	Scaling Pains <i>Case study: a fast-growing company that over-indexed on headcount. What breaks first — coordination costs, mission clarity, or manager load — and why.</i>	- McChrystal, Stanley, Team of Teams, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2015) — Portfolio — the paradigmatic account of complexity overcoming hierarchy - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Scaling Pains section) (2026) — @arcktip — the Google/Meta/Uber scaling case analysis - HBS Case: Spotify's Agile Model (Kniberg & Ivarsson)	- McChrystal, Stanley, Team of Teams, Introduction & Ch. 1–5 (2015) — Portfolio - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Scaling Pains) (2026) — @arcktip - HBS Case: Spotify's Agile Model (Kniberg & Ivarsson) - Greiner, Larry, Evolution and Revolution as Organizations Grow (1972) — HBR — five phases of organizational growth and their crises

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			- Christensen, Clayton & Raynor, Michael, The Innovator's Solution, Ch. 8 (Disruptive Management Practices) (2003) — HBS Press — org design and innovation capacity - Pfeffer, Jeffrey, Managing with Power, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1992) — HBS Press — political dynamics in growing organizations - Sutton, Robert, The No Asshole Rule, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2007) — Business Plus — culture preservation under rapid scaling
6	Platform vs. Product Teams <i>The platform team trap: how to structure shared infrastructure without creating internal bottlenecks. Who owns the platform, and what does product team autonomy actually require?</i>	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 25–27 (Platform Teams) (2020) — SVPG — the platform team model - Skelton, Matthew & Pais, Manuel, Team Topologies, Introduction & Ch. 1–2 (2019) — IT Revolution — four team types and three interaction modes - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Platform vs. Product section) (2026) — @arcktip — the JUMP/Superpedestrian case of platform org design	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 25–28 (2020) - Skelton, Matthew & Pais, Manuel, Team Topologies, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2019) — IT Revolution - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Platform vs. Product) (2026) — @arcktip - Gawer, Annabelle & Cusumano, Michael, Platform Leadership, Introduction & Ch. 1–2 (2002) — HBS Press — platform governance from the outside; now applied inside an org - Henderson, Rebecca & Clark, Kim, Architectural Innovation: The Reconfiguration of Existing Product Technologies (1990) — Administrative Science Quarterly — how org structure shapes innovation type - MacCormack, Alan et al., Exploring the Duality Between Product and Organizational Architectures (2012) — Management Science — the empirical case for Conway's Law - Baldwin, Carliss & Clark, Kim, Design Rules, Volume 1, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2000) — MIT Press — modularity in both product and org design
7	The Agentic Era <i>How AI agents are changing the calculus of team structure. When software executes autonomously, what does a product team own, and how does the Rule of Seven apply?</i>	- Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Agentic Era section) (2026) — @arcktip — the most forward-looking chapter; course's original contribution - Cagan, Marty, Transformed: Moving to the Product Operating Model, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2024) — SVPG — the post-AI product model - Brynjolfsson, Erik & McAfee, Andrew, The Second Machine Age, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2014) — Norton — the economic context of automation and org change	- Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Agentic Era) (2026) — @arcktip - Cagan, Marty, Transformed, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2024) — SVPG - Brynjolfsson, Erik & McAfee, Andrew, The Second Machine Age, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2014) — Norton - Autor, David, Work of the Past, Work of the Future (2019) — AEA Papers and Proceedings — labor market effects of automation; context for org change - Acemoglu, Daron & Restrepo, Pascual, Robots and Jobs: Evidence from US Labor Markets (2020) — Journal of Political Economy — empirical effects on org structure - Simon, Herbert, The Architecture of Complexity (1962) — Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society — hierarchies

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			and complex systems Russell, Stuart, Human Compatible, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2019) — Viking — AI agency and its implications for human organization
8	Midterm Case Students diagnose an organizational dysfunction case and present a redesign recommendation with rationale, trade-offs, and an implementation outline.	- Case: Amazon's Two-Pizza Teams (selected HBS or Galloway reading) - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Diagnostic Framework section) (2026) — @arcktip — the diagnostic framework used in the midterm	- Case: Amazon's Two-Pizza Teams (selected HBS or Galloway reading) - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Diagnostic Framework) (2026) — @arcktip - Nadler, David & Tushman, Michael, Competing by Design, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1997) — Oxford UP — congruence model for organizational diagnosis - Weisbord, Marvin, Organizational Diagnosis: A Workbook of Theory and Practice, Introduction (1978) — Addison-Wesley — the six-box model for org analysis
9	Cross-functional Collaboration Designer, PM, engineer: who owns what, and how to structure decision rights across disciplines without org chart battles or design-by-committee.	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 10–14 (Coaching and Collaboration) (2020) — SVPG — how product, design, and engineering collaborate - Edmondson, Amy, The Fearless Organization, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2018) — Wiley — the precondition for cross-functional truth-telling - Lencioni, Patrick, The Five Dysfunctions of a Team, Introduction (2002) — Jossey-Bass — the dysfunctions that kill cross-functional work	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 10–16 (2020) - Edmondson, Amy, The Fearless Organization, Introduction & Ch. 1–5 (2018) — Wiley - Lencioni, Patrick, The Five Dysfunctions of a Team, Introduction & Pt. I (2002) — Jossey-Bass - Ancona, Deborah & Caldwell, David, Demography and Design: Predictors of New Product Team Performance (1992) — Organization Science — cross-functional team composition and performance - Eisenhardt, Kathleen & Tabrizi, Behnam, Accelerating Adaptive Processes: Product Innovation in the Global Computer Industry (1995) — Administrative Science Quarterly — compression vs. experiential learning in cross-functional product teams - Katzenbach, Jon & Smith, Douglas, The Wisdom of Teams, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1993) — HBS Press — the difference between a team and a working group - Argyris, Chris, Double Loop Learning in Organizations (1977) — HBR — how cross-functional teams avoid defensive routines
10	Enterprise Org Design Managing hundreds of PMs: portfolio structure, P&L ownership, CPO responsibilities, and how the	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 28–32 (Scaling Product Leadership) (2020) — SVPG — the CPO's organizational challenge - Lafley, A.G. & Martin, Roger, Playing to Win, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2013) — HBS Press — cascading choices and portfolio	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 28–33 (2020) - Lafley, A.G. & Martin, Roger, Playing to Win, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (2013) — HBS Press - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams

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	org design problem changes at 10x scale.	strategy Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Enterprise Org Design section) (2026) — @arcktip — the Google and Meta org design cases	for the Agentic Era (Enterprise Org Design) (2026) — @arcktip - Galbraith, Jay, Designing the Global Corporation, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2000) — Jossey-Bass — matrix structures and their pathologies - Goold, Michael & Campbell, Andrew, Designing Effective Organizations, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2002) — Jossey-Bass — the nine design tests - Prahalad, C.K. & Doz, Yves, The Multinational Mission, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1987) — Free Press — integration vs. responsiveness in complex org structures - Bower, Joseph, Managing the Resource Allocation Process, Introduction (1970) — HBS Press — how org structure shapes which products get built
11	Executive Guest Session A senior product leader on the organizational decisions that shaped — or constrained — their roadmap. Structured interview format followed by student Q&A.	No assigned reading — prepare one written question for the guest based on the course frameworks.	- Edmondson, Amy, The Fearless Organization, Ch. 6–8 (Creating Psychological Safety) (2018) — Wiley — to frame questions about how the guest creates speaking-up conditions - McChrystal, Stanley, Team of Teams, Ch. 6–8 (Shared Consciousness in Practice) (2015) — Portfolio — to frame questions about information flow across the guest's org - No additional reading — prepare two written questions at graduate depth.
12	Mergers & Reorgs What happens to product org structure during M&A. Integration playbooks, the cost of culture collision, and the PM's role when the org chart changes.	- Kanter, Rosabeth Moss, When Giants Learn to Dance, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1989) — Simon & Schuster — post-merger org integration challenges - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Reorgs section) (2026) — @arcktip — the JUMP/Uber integration case as a reorg model - Case: Netflix Culture Deck (Hastings & McCord, 2009 — original slide deck)	- Kanter, Rosabeth Moss, When Giants Learn to Dance, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (1989) — Simon & Schuster - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Reorgs) (2026) — @arcktip - Case: Netflix Culture Deck (Hastings & McCord, 2009) - Haspeslagh, Philippe & Jemison, David, Managing Acquisitions, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1991) — Free Press — the capability transfer and strategic interdependence framework - Buono, Anthony & Bowditch, James, The Human Side of Mergers and Acquisitions, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1989) — Jossey-Bass — cultural integration as org design - Schein, Edgar, Organizational Culture and Leadership, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2010) — Jossey-Bass — culture as the invisible org design constraint - Puranam, Phanish & Srikanth, Kannan, What They Know vs. What They Do: How Acquirers Leverage Technology Acquisitions (2007) — Strategic Management Journal — post-

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			acquisition knowledge integration
13	Mentorship as Leverage <i>How investing in PM development compounds — and why mentorship and coaching are the highest-leverage activities for a senior product leader.</i>	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 17–18 (Coaching Product Managers) (2020) — SVPG — the manager-as-coach model for product leaders - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Mentorship as Leverage section) (2026) — @arcktip — the compounding return on PM development investment - Scott, Kim, Radical Candor, Introduction & Ch. 1–2 (2017) — St. Martin's Press — care personally, challenge directly	- Cagan, Marty & Jones, Chris, Empowered, Ch. 17–20 (2020) - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Mentorship as Leverage) (2026) — @arcktip - Scott, Kim, Radical Candor, Introduction & Ch. 1–4 (2017) — St. Martin's Press - Kegan, Robert & Lahey, Lisa, An Everyone Culture, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2016) — HBS Press — the deliberately developmental organization - Ibarra, Herminia, Act Like a Leader, Think Like a Leader, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2015) — HBS Press — leadership identity through action - Dweck, Carol, Mindset, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2006) — Random House — growth mindset as an org design input - Drucker, Peter, The Effective Executive, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1967) — HarperBusiness — managing one's own development as a leader
14	Leading the Redesign <i>How to socialize, implement, and sustain an organizational change. Stakeholder mapping, resistance management, and the PM's political toolkit.</i>	- Kotter, John, Leading Change, Introduction & Ch. 1–3 (1996) — HBS Press — the eight-stage model for organizational change - Edmondson, Amy, The Fearless Organization, Ch. 7 (Making It Happen) (2018) — Wiley — creating safety as a prerequisite for change - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Leading the Redesign section) (2026) — @arcktip — the step-by-step playbook for org change in a product team	- Kotter, John, Leading Change, Introduction & Ch. 1–5 (1996) — HBS Press - Edmondson, Amy, The Fearless Organization, Ch. 7–8 (2018) — Wiley - Hoffman, Patrick T., The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Leading the Redesign) (2026) — @arcktip - Heifetz, Ronald & Linsky, Marty, Leadership on the Line, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2002) — HBS Press — adaptive change vs. technical change - Pfeffer, Jeffrey, Power: Why Some People Have It and Others Don't, Introduction & Ch. 1 (2010) — HarperBusiness — the political dimension of org redesign - Schein, Edgar, Process Consultation Revisited, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1998) — Addison-Wesley — how to help an organization change - Nadler, David, Champions of Change, Introduction & Ch. 1 (1998) — Jossey-Bass — implementing large-scale organizational change
15	Final Presentations <i>Teams present a full</i>	No assigned reading — final presentation preparation only.	No assigned reading — final presentation day.

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	<i>organizational design proposal for a real or simulated company: current-state diagnosis, redesign recommendation, trade-off analysis, and implementation plan.</i>		Hoffman, Patrick T., <i>The Rule of Seven: Architecting Teams for the Agentic Era (Conclusion)</i> (2026) — @arcktip — optional synthesis essay; the practitioner's org design checklist

Reading Notes

Titles in italic are assigned texts. 'Ch.' indicates specific chapters only. HBS Cases available via Harvard Business Publishing.

@arcktip sources (Hoffman) anchor the course in practitioner reality — drawn from product leadership at Social Bicycles/JUMP, Google, Meta, Udacity, and from the Rule of Seven framework developed through hands-on organizational work across startup, growth-stage, and enterprise contexts.

This is a case-method course. Readings are selected to equip students to diagnose, recommend, and lead organizational change — not primarily to survey organizational theory. The rule: if the reading cannot be applied to a real case in the room, it is not in the list.